

quidquid Romani nobis aliquando operati?

De Bello Britannico

*adstupet ipse sibi correptus imagine formae,
qui quondam conatus aquas contingere manu est
Atlantis, nunc Romanos in proelia ducit
cum patribus populoque, penatibus et magnis dis.
aspice quam laeta cingantur tempora nube, 5
et quam stans celsa in puppi uomat ille per undas!
non secus Heliades patrias contorsit habenas
curribus aetheriis et uenit ad ultima mundi
quoque eat aut ubi sit, picea caligine tectus,
nescit, sic praeceps inuoluitur undique fumo 10
ignotas penetrans tenebras, qua desinit orbis
terrarum et maesto miscetur murmure caelum.
at cursum tenuit rectum flatusque secundos
nec subito periit – sed Fors sua munera poscit:
filia namque animam exspirauit post breue tempus 15
hostia quam superi pro cursu rite probarant.
quis tam crudelis optauit sumere poenas?
quisue Britannica tam demens ad litora uenit,
uidit et hanc terram uicisse putauit in aeuum?*

*Caesar Iulius est, unus qui talia gessit, 20
quem septingenti naues et sex legionum
robora et incursus equitum bis mille iuuabant.
extensa subter classi late latet aequor,
fessi nunc omnes ad laeuam uela retorquent,
adnixa torquent spumas et caerula uerrunt 25
mentibus ardentes: niueas pars quaerere bacas
carae quas matri referant sponsaeque domorum;
parsque triumphali iam sese ostendere pompa
plumbum induta album; plus quam ciuilia iura
pars retinere et mox populo regalior esse. 30*

nunc triplici gelidis e nubibus ordine rupes
cretosae subito surgunt, simul imminet imber
his ratibus, ceu Scylla madens seno ore tridenti.
ingemitant pinus uacuae, uelut aegra dolentum
corpora suppliciis, quae stabant robore in aruis 35
Gallorum, at Latia domitae iam clade bipennis
admonuere suas quercus in litore amicas.

amplior en uasto consurgit limite uertex!
Caesar at aspiciens populos in colle minaces
stipatos latitare uidet currusque uenire, 40
dentibus infrendit torpens titubansque resistit.
hic subito saxis ui Roma Britanniae adempta
frangitur in partes: nauis deinde altera nauis
insequitur strepitu horrendo; clamoribus aether
personat, et Liridae nunc una dextra profundum 45
ad regnum trahit infelices; ossibus aras
nunc pelagi decorant domini sub gurgite uasto.
at fera equi memores hinnitu fata futura
praesagunt, trepidantque metu – nam proxima caedes
imminet, atque imber mixtus sudore madescit. 50

attollens umero famamque et fata parentum
surgit et hos inter fremitus uox regia: "Ciues,
Romani, comites, auris aduertite uestras.
heu, quantum Fortuna umeris iam pondus ademit!
Idibus in caelo feruenti Luna refulsit: 55
Mars dedit hoc nostras qui caedes ipse probaret.
O fortunatam natam me principe Romam!
uobiscum stabo: nos confligemus in oris,
in uicis pugnabimus atque oriemur in agris
colleque uincemus; numquam parebimus hosti! 60

*regnes, Romuleum regnum! regnes sine fine,
Romani numquam serui pede uincula portent.
pergite, Dardanidae, requiescite!” substitit undis
“venit summa dies” uaginaque eripit ensem
fulmineum, strictoque ferit retinacula ferro.*

65

*idem omnis simul ardor habet, rapiuntque ruuntque;
ut cum carceribus sese effudere quadrigae,
addunt in spatia et frustra retinacula tendens
fertur equis auriga neque audit currus habenas.
sed postquam, limo haerente aluo, per uada classis
defecit. per harenam illo descenderat atram
(aestate hic cernes castella, atque incola ludo
uici conueniet taurum et canum propius pontum
Aegaea qua de palma concurrere erit mos,
carne assata, dum tuberes piscesque uorantur).*

70

*nunc nihil. Astur equus (cui sunt plantaria forma
humana ac digiti et floret iuba crine soluto)
uix transuersum unguem discedit – scandere Caesar
si temptauisset, quantum mutata fuissent
fata! sed in mediis haeret legio ipsa paludis.*

75

80

*en quaedam mediis pallens se immiscuit armis
femina, per series sinuans serpentis in arte
sibilat, et diris implet praecordia uerbis.
dum, de more suo, instruxit regina cateruas
trinis agminibus longis (gens ordine gaudens)*

85

*Britonumque acies, quīs terga sagitta tuetur,
at medium retinent equites peditesque feroces.
nos pauci (fratrum nos felix grex) iaculamur
tela alte, nec cessamus dare uulnera turbae.
crescunt paulatim cumuli caedis, super ictos*

90

*signiferi gradiuntur uti per lilia Nymphae,
donec humum siccam tangant, ubi denique signum
figunt; inuita in caelum super aurea penna
ales Romana infaustos uolitare per agros
cogitur. imperium paruae quis crederet orae
complexurum orbem et plus quam Romanum oriturum?*

95

*iamque sagi sandyce frequens exercitus illic
uirgineam ripam complet, ceu femina rupto
partu sanguineum sanguen uiolata marito
effundit mixtoque luto putentia membra
uisceraque et fetum bacchatur; terra rubescit
uirginea et primum nunc dedecoratur ab hoste.
tollitur in caelum clamor cui carmina contra
dein druidae Donni domino discordia dictant.*

100

*ipse Ignotus, qui ob promissa reliquerat aegre
uxorem maestam puerumque ut proelia sumat,
gloriane an reditus melior dum mente uolutat,
contra pugnat aquas aduersaque flumina rumpit
et modo distentis umeris modo pectore uasto,
prosilit ante alios, clipeo gladioque tremendus
miles, et in medias audet se mittere clades.*

105

110

*quattuor hic solus (fidens astare magistrum
Caesareum) aggreditur; rapto de corpore pilo
transfigit geminos uno conamine fratres.
tertius ense cadit – per costas guttura ruptus,
et sanie casu perfundit lumina mortis.*

115

*caecus at ille furens animis teloque peregit,
talum traiectus geminum (sors aspera!) campo
labitur, et ueluti cum flos succisus aratro
languescit moriens lassoue papauera collo*

120

demisere caput, pluuiā cum forte grauantur.
dumque retro cedit fraternaue rebus in artis
respicit auxilia et nullam uidet esse salutem,
sensit adesse dolos. quid agat? quae numina poscat?
nec memoratus erit nec sospes; uulnera mandunt 125
cancer et obsceni pisces, noua tecta petentes.
quare nos quoque ad hoc tempus sine nomine membra
Militis Ignoti ferimus tumulanda sepulcro
quae celebrantur iam redimita papauere campi.

undique pugnatum est, passim permixta cruore 130
uiscera cum cerebro; fluitant in gurgite nerui
et tremuli digiti atque ingentes corpore trunci.
Mars, super arridens, Neptuno sanguine fauces
oppresso gaudet, dum iam Nereides omnes
cum Genetrice oras lamentis rursus inundant, 135
interea Parcae, modo quae per stamina cursus
texuerant longos imitantes turbine telum,
accelerant digitis madidis et sanguine tinctis.

tempus iners abiit: numquam sol occidit omni
Britonum imperio, donec Victoria tandem 140
Forsque lupae fauit, verterunt terga leones,
in litus Caesar rapide descendit, et inter
membra uirumque natat, sicut cum bracchia quondam
tendebant ad eum Romae orabantque fauorem.
terram ubi desertam faciat pacemque reportet, 145
propterea uicti in uexillo proelia pingunt:
candida gens: rubor est cruciformis tinctus in albo
campo dum Scoto e creta cruor undique fluctu
tergatur. sic a nullo damnabitur aeuo
dimidium nostrum historiae. 150

1-19 Proem

The topic of 'Caesar landing in Britain' is introduced indirectly through three mythological figures: Narcissus, Phaethon and Agamemnon. Until C. is explicitly named on line 20, the key themes of self-delusion and imperial overreach are universalised.

1-2 adstupet... manu est: the myth of Narcissus entranced by and interacting with his own reflection (Ov. *M.* 3.416-8) characterises C.'s narcissism. **imagine:** anticipates the final three lines of the proem, how C.'s (and anyone's) campaign in Britain is just a vain illusion. **qui... contingere:** percussive alliteration presents C.'s imperial expansion forcefully and conveys early the narrator's (not yet) explicit contempt. **quondam... manu:** has two meanings, (1) referencing C.'s literal 'hand', like Narcissus; (2) his 'band of men' and first attempt to invade Britain in August 55 BC which, line 147 refers back to as part of the poem's ring-composition.

3 Atlantis: the enjambement delays the clarification of *aquas*, preserving the image of Narcissus for as long as possible, and again has two meanings, (1) 'the Atlantic sea' through which, according to Plutarch, C. was the first to sail with an army to wage war (Plut. 23.2); (2) 'the waters of Atlas' in the Iberian Peninsula, beyond the 'Pillars of Hercules', where, in an anecdote by Suetonius, C. during his time as governor in Further Spain saw a statue of Alexander the Great in the Temple of Hercules and cried that as such a young age Alexander had already accomplished so much while he had idled for all his youth (Suet. *Iul.* 7-8). The latter, as the symbolic start of C.'s imperialistic ambitions, parallels the expedition at hand.

3-6 nunc Romanos... undas: the depiction of Augustus on the shield of Aeneas (Verg. *A.* 8.679-81), leading the whole of Italy at the Battle of Actium, is here shrunk to Rome alone, and the ascending tricolon of Roman institutions here foreshadows C.'s hubris in claiming divine support., **nube:** 'the sea fog' is delayed last on the line so that momentarily the image of C. wearing a crown is at play, and plays as an ambiguous metaphor for C.'s mind being obnubilated by the sickness of the voyage. **stans... vomat:** C. seemingly stands in the epic, commanding pose of Augustus but here *uomere* is intransitive and thus C. actually stands puking over the side of the ship. The sly jab in this context nods to Lucan's *sentient axis onus* in his invocation to Nero (Luc. 1.56-7).

7-12 Hubris has brought C. to the edge of the world just as it did Phaethon. **qua... caelum:** Britain was regarded as a place of mystery (Hor. *Carm.* 1.35.29, 4.14.47; Sen. *Apocol.* 2.13.2), with some writers denying its existence (Plut. *Iul.* 23.2) and, even after speaking to merchants while in Gaul, C. reported that he could not gauge the size of Britain or its population (Caes. *BGall.* 4.20). **maestuo... caelum:** the *m* sounds create a sonorous haze, complementing C.'s movement through sea-fog.

13-6 The favourable winds and tide which C. reports (Caes. *BGall.* 4.23) are reimagined as a divine trade-off akin to Agamemnon's sacrifice of Iphigenia at Aulis to secure winds for the Greek fleet's passage to Troy. **hostia:** refers specifically to C.'s daughter, Julia, who died in childbirth in August 54 BC, a few weeks after C. began his second invasion of Britain.

15 The ephthemimeral caesura of line 15 renders Julia's dying breath.

17-9 The narrator's contempt is here made explicit as the anaphora of *quis* emphasises outrage. **venit vidit... vicisse putauit:** the popular catchphrase which, according to Appian, C. used in a letter to the Roman Senate after the Battle of Zela in 47 BC, is here repurposed to undermine the certainty of C.'s success.

20-30 Caesar's fleet

C. and his fleet come into view as they slowly sail toward Britain, tired but motivated by various prospects.

20 Caesar Iulius est: The swift declaration breaks the mythological anonymity, and represents the narrator's more historical approach to epic – the proem contains no invocation to the Muse – relying instead on statistics and empirical evidence.

20-2 unus... iuvabunt: C. is isolated by *unus* and credited fully until the extended tricolon describing his forces, polysyndeton, and four starting spondees of line 21 slowly and awkwardly pan out to acknowledge the

huge army truly responsible for *talia gessit*. **septingenti... sex... bis mille**: roughly match the numbers reported by Caesar (Caes. *BGall.* 4.22).

23-5 extensa... verrunt: three consecutive lines each with four starting spondees now painfully convey the fleet's sheer magnitude and slow advance, and the repetitive motion of rowing. The pace and velocity of Caesar in his own narratives is here reversed, and he is characteristically steady throughout the poem.

25-30 The Romans are here linked by moments in the *Aeneid* to three people(s) adjacent to Carthage: (1) Aeneas' crew departing (4.583); (2) Dido in the Underworld (6.467-8); (3) the Tyrians constructing their city upon Aeneas' arrival (1.423-6). **adnixa... uerrunt**: whereas Aeneas's crew steered away from a foreign nation and toward Rome, they are here leaving Rome to reach a foreign nation. **mentibus ardentes**: the Romans are controlled by their emotions and not motivated by *pietas* like Aeneas. **pars... parsque... pars**: what was an inspiring prospect of unity for Aeneas has, in fact, not manifested as his descendants are motivated by earthly desires and personal ambition.

26-30 The soldiers' motivations unfold in ascending order of ambition: *basas* (pearls), *plumbum album* (tin), *plus quam civilia iura* (veteran status). The triple correlatives also present a profile of C.'s various motivations. According to Suetonius, C. wanted to obtain pearls (Suet. *Iul.* 47), and C. reported his obtaining tin (Caes. *BGall.* 5.12). However, C.'s motivations are here refigured against Pompey. **matri... sponsae** suggests that the Romans' motivations are more earnest than they might have seemed initially but, regarding C., alludes to Julia whom he betrothed to Pompey (and *sacrificed* upon becoming a mother), and suggests C. is already looking to arrange a new alliance. **triumphali... pompa** alludes to Pompey's name, and his rivalry with C. regarding military prestige.

26 niueas... album: the colouring of Britain and the Britons as 'snowy', 'white', 'pale', 'chalky', 'virgin', 'candid' etc. lays the foundations for lines 147-50.

29 plumbum induta album: the double elision illustrates the subject clothed in tin.

29-30 plus quam civilia iura: modifies Lucan's reference to 'war worse than civil' (Luc. 1.1). The civil war between C. and Pompey has not yet begun but it and C.'s regal ambitions loom at large.

31-50 Britain appears

The scene expands as the coastline of Britain emerges from the mist and the Romans fall victim to the elements.

31-2 nunc... subito... simul: the scene changes and pace quickens unexpectedly as if C. has now pierced through the ecological cloak (cf. line 45) protecting Britain and faces the new challenge of rain.

31-3 triplici... tridenti: the White Cliffs of Dover are compared to the three rows of teeth in each of Scylla's six heads (Hom. *Od.* 12.91).

34-7 pinus... robore... quercus: two tree-based wordplays, (1) *pinus* functions as the 'pine trees' related to *quercus* as well as synecdoche for the Romans' ships; (2) *robor* functions as the 'stumps' after the trees have been cut down as well as a foreboding synonym of *quercus*. Pliny the Elder documented the Celtic ritual of oak and mistletoe and suggested that the word *druis* (druid) is borrowed from δρῦς (Plin. *Nat.* 16.95), making the Gallic trees sacred and thus echo Lucan's sacred grove near Massilia (Luc. 3.399-452). **amicas**: the anthropomorphised trees further dramatises C.'s ecocide.

34 uacuae: equivalent to the Homeric ship-epithet κοῖλος (hollow), restating their wishes to fill the ships.

38-40 en... aspiciens... videt currusque uenire: the narrative focus darts from the narrator's eyes to C.'s, zooming into the British cliff-tops.

38 amplior... uertex: has three meanings, (1) 'the crown of the head', recalling *cingantur tempora* on line 5; (2) 'a taller summit' than C. standing high on his prow on line 6; (3) 'a stronger whirlpool' aggrandising Scylla on line 33. Ultimately, the physical hierarchy shifts from C. to something greater, something British.

39-41 Caesar was dissuaded from landing initially because of the massed Britons gathered on the overlooking hills (Caes. *BGall.* 4.23).

41-2 dentibus infrendit... saxis: recalls Vergil's Hercules 'gnashing his teeth' and overpowering the rock with which Cacus closed his cave (Verg. *A.* 8.230-5) but the subsequent dental alliteration and shipwrecking illustrates C. 'chattering his teeth' and being overpowered by a rock.

42-5 hic subito... personat: again, the scene changes and pace quickens but the focus is now sonic.

42 Roma Britanniae: The arrangement illustrates the personifications of Roma and Britannia literally clashing.

45 Liridae: Manannán mac Lir (the son of Ler, the Celtic sea-god) would cloak the whereabouts of his home in his *féth fiada* (mist of invisibility), and was associated with storms that occur when ships are wrecked. His three legs (the heraldic arms of Man) represent his whirling motion, making him comparable to *Scylla*, *vertex*, *gurgite* as well as Neptune. This delayed insight into Celtic religion and the primordial escalation of the scene, relates us to C. and the unaware Romans.

48-50 primus... madescit: the prophetic horses in the context of drying men groaning alludes to Calpurnia's dream about the Ides of March in Shakespeare's *Julius Caesar* 2.2.22-4. **sudore** is a tactile insight, complementing the visual and sonic, suggesting both fear and prophetic power.

51-65 Caesar rallies his troops

C.'s sets out with Aenean intentions to deliver a rousing speech to his men, the content of which is a mixture of other speeches mostly about British patriotism and popular culture.

51-4 attollens umero... parentum: C. feels the opposite weight Aeneas had on his shoulders when lifting up the shield Vulcan made for him, unaware of the greatness of his future descendants (*A.* 8.731), C. must live up to the legacy of his ancestors. **heu... umeri... ademit:** Lucan's C. proclaims during the stormy sea that he has the *Fortuna Caesaris* on his side (Luc. 5.354), and when applied in combination with the image of Aeneas, the polyptoton of *umerus* presents C. as weak and lazy – immediately relieved to have Fortune remove said weight. **vox regia** Aeneas pioneered the Julian legacy while C.'s rejection of republican values does the opposite.

52-3 Cives... vestras: recalls the beginning of Mark Antony's eulogy for C. according to Shakespeare, 'Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears' (*Shakespeare Julius Caesar*. 3.2.14-5)

55-6 The natural phenomenon of a blood moon is misinterpreted, C. sees it as Mars approving his invasion; the reference to the Ides and Mars, the namesake of March, as well as *nostras caedes* which functions as both 'our killing that we are about to make happen' and 'my assassination' (if understood as the royal 'we' and poetic plural) is a dramatically ironic wink at C.'s assassination on the Ides of March in 44 BC.

57 principe: what is republican bombast with Cicero, becomes imperial delusion. The four starting spondees supports the characterisation of C. as slow.

58 uobiscum stabo: this appears uniquely Caesarean yet will be a promise he fails to keep. Technically, C. speaks truthfully as, through the continual use of the verbs *stare* and *sistere* C. always 'stands' in the background (cf. lines 6, 41, 63).

58-60 nos conflagemus... hosti: C. unknowingly quotes Winston Churchill's *We Shall fight on the beaches* speech from June 1940.

61-2 C. sings a Romanified version of James Thomson's *Rule Britannia* (1740), most strongly associated with the Royal Navy, plump with assonance and tacky alliteration – perhaps best translated as 'Rule, Romulean realm! Rule without end: / Romans will never be enslaved by their feet'. **pede vincula** is a pun on the conventions and restrictions of metrical feet which C. frequently ignores.

61 regnum... sine fine: C. has bastardised Vergil's *imperium sine fine* into a *regnum sine fine*.

63 pergite... requiescite: C. inverts the *Keep Calm and Carry On* motivational posters produced by the UK Government in 1939 in preparation for WWII, thus undermining their message.

63 substitit undis: At the climax of his speech, C. is still subject to the waves – one must think back to his seasickness and the *undas* of line 6.

63-4 Dardanidae: only by the end of his speech does C. embody Aeneas but the vocative is weak, as though he mistakenly deadnames the Romans, or was so swept up by his regal ambitions that embodying Aeneas actually became an afterthought. **uenit summa dies** C. actually quotes Panthus' proclamation of Troy's destruction (Verg. *A.* 2.324), which following on from *Dardanidae* foreshadows the slaughter of his men. Additionally, following on from Churchill's speech, *summa dies* alludes to his subsequent *This was their finest hour* speech from 1940, though C. actually waited 5 hours for other ships to arrive. (Caes. *BGall.* 4.23).

64-5 uaginaque... ferro: C. slashes the mooring ropes as Aeneas did to not risk his burning of his ships (Verg. *A.* 4.579-80) except in C.'s case this signals that there is no turning back.

66-80 Stuck in the mud

The fleet accelerates forward but quickly finds itself encumbered by the muddy shore and, as the narrator digresses about Britain's beaches during the summer, we too are held in position.

66 rapiuntque ruuntque: the Romans – whether inspired by C.'s speech or threatened by his slashing the mooring ropes – again become Aeneas' crew departing (Verg. *A.* 4.581).

67-9 Virgil's simile comparing Mars raging over the world to a runaway chariot whose charioteer struggles to control his horses (cf. Virg. *G.* 1.511-4) is here repurposed and C. becomes the charioteer wanting to slow down but is unable to without mooring ropes. The Romans become the horses or, by transferred analogy, Mars raging which is not civil war but imperial expansion; when taken with line 56, the Romans' approval of C.'s assassination is also implied.

70 limo haerente aluo: 'stuck in the mud' the words literally stick together through elision, and the four starting spondees convey the deceleration of the fleet. The other possibility that C.'s slashing the mooring ropes prevented them from landing properly is also implicit.

71 per harenam... descenderat: has two interpretations, (1) 'had sunk through the sand/mud/beach'; and, by extending the gladiatorial theme of lines 67-9, (2) 'had stepped through into the arena'.

72-5 cernes: in Herodotean fashion the narrator digresses, providing an ethnography about the British beach during summer. To a Roman or non-British reader, the coast seems feverish with its castles, animal games, Grecian races, flesh cooking, and devouring of *tuber* (tumour) and fishes. The simplified descriptions purposefully leave a lot unanswered but, at face value, Britain certainly seems barbaric and pugnacious. To a British reader, however, the quintessential British summer is portrayed: *casetlla* become sandcastles; *ludo... taurum et canum* the tag-based playground game 'British bulldog'; *pontum... mos* the famous slow-motion beach run from the *Chariots of Fire* (1981) drama about Eric Liddell and Harold Abrahams training to win the Olympic gold; *carne assata* sunburn; and *tuberes piscesque* fish and chips.

76 nunc nihil: The bubble is quickly burst and the narrative continues.

76-80 Astur equus... fata: C. reported that his army's horses were hampered by the sea and could not reach the shore, commenting that *hoc unum ad pristinam fortunam Caesari defuit* (Caes. *BGall.* 4.26). Here the narrator specifies C.'s horse who, according to Pliny, had the forefeet of a human (Plin. *NH.* 8.64), and comments that the fates would have been different indeed, implying that C. might have been killed had he actually tried to fight. **uix tranuersum unguem discedit:** delivers a joke—one that, like all jokes, risks losing its charm when dissected. The humour hinges on Latin idiom 'not to depart a nail's breath' (e.g. Cic. *Att.* 13.20.4; Plaut. *Aul.* 1.1.17; Hier. *Ep.* 127.8) and here *unguis* can mean both a fingernail and a hoof. If Asturcus has fingers instead of hooves, he barely moves a fingernail's breath; if he has hooves, he still barely moves a nail's breadth.

80 in mediis... paludis: echoes line 70 and the word order illustrates the legion's entrapment in the mud. The ring-composition of this section reinforces the sense of being 'stuck in the mud' – a phrase that gains new significance after the ethnographical digression, evoking not just physical entrapment but also the tag-based playground game of the same name.

81-96 British defence

The British queen draws up her army into three long ranks while her archers rain down arrows on the disembarking Romans. Ultimately, the Roman standard-bearers reach dry land by climbing over their slain comrades.

81-9: en... cessamus: the Roman-based narrative of the poem has fully shifted following the narrator's nostalgic digression (cf. lines 72-5). **nos:** the narrator reveals their British identity, as if it were not already obvious, and steps away from their historical responsibilities with *iaculamur* and *cessamus* inserting themselves into the narrative, so we too join the British army. **gens ordine gaudens:** is an ethnographical titbit regarding Brits being great at organising themselves into a queue, and can also be seen as pride in protecting their country.

81-3 femina... regina... verbis: the unnamed woman compared to a snake both explicitly and through sibilance, corresponds with *regina*. The queen goes unnamed, just as Caesar was initially, and is here comparable to Allecto flinging a snake into Queen Amata's breast, and rousing Turnus (Verg. *A.* 7.346-53, 445-67). **se:** is literally hidden through its elision (V. *G.* 4.245; *A.* 11.815) and The *regina* in charge of the Britons against the Romans inevitably calls Boudica to mind but I do not lean into this considerably. The *regina* more serves to combat Caesar *rex*.

84-7 de more... Feroces: She arranges the men on the hill into the battle *formation*. **de more suo:** refers to (1) female monarchs and leaders such as Boudica, which serve as the yin to the yang of *Caesar rex*; (2) the formation Henry V used in October 1415 at the Battle of Agincourt, chosen for its association with rain and a muddy battlefield. Henry V deployed his outnumbered forces with longbowmen on the flanks, dismounted knights and men-at-arms in the centre, and additional archers positioned to funnel the French into a killing zone.

88-9 nos pauci... turbae: the narrator inserts themselves into Shakespeare's *Henry V* 4.3.62 and takes part in the killing of Romans. According to Plutarch, the Britons attacked the foremost centurions while they wrestled with the watery marsh (Plut. 16.5).

91 signiferi: according to C. the standard bearer of the tenth legion advanced first (Caes. *BGall* 4.25).

91 lilia Nymphae: functions simply as lily-pads, or as the bizarre juxtaposition to a Nymph jumping on lilies.

94-5 inuita... cogitur: the Roman *aquila* is here animated yet trapped by the weight of its metal body and forced to comply with Roman imperial expansion.

95-6 imperium... oriturum: the narrator removes themselves from the Britons' narrative to reflect on the British empire out-doing Roman expansionism. **complexurum orbem et:** literally consumes *orbem*. **plus quam Romanum** echoes line 29 and Lucan's *incipit*.

97-104 The Romans *flood* the shore

The moment of Roman landing is rendered through the poem's most viscerally violent imagery, comparing the violation of British soil to miscarriage.

97-102 sandyce: the 'bright red' of their cloaks spreads across the horizontal plain. **virgineum... virginea:** the polyptoton reinforces the image of Britain as 'innocent' and 'white', being deflowered by Roman red.

97 frequens exercitus: C. reported that the Romans quickly established themselves after the standard bearer reached the shore (Caes. *B Gall.* 4.25).

102 hoste: the narrator refers to the Romans as *hostes* whereas C. refers to the Britons as such (cf. line 60).

98-101: the simile of miscarriage alludes to the poem's classification of Julia Caesar's death as divine retribution for C.'s invasion into Britain (cf. lines 13-6).

103-4 tollitur... dictant: the cutting *c* sounds and thumping *d* sounds create a percussive clash on the vertical plain with the two verbs distanced from each other as much as possible, their arrangement on respective lines, and the setting of the Britons still occupying the high-ground and the Romans speaking *in caelum*.

104 Donni domino: Donn (the Celtic god of the dead) whom C. equated to *Dis Pater* (Caes. *B Gall.* 6.18).

105-29 The *aristeia* of the Unknown Warrior

One man from the Roman army disembarks and wades through the water while considering his homecoming, until he suddenly bursts through the front lines and, while heroically taking on four Britons, dies tragically, without support from his comrades and without anyone to protect his corpse.

105-6 promissa: a Roman conscripted as part of national service echoes *civilia iura* on line 29. **Ignotus** the name establishes Odyssean themes, functioning as *nemo* or οὐτις (*Od.* 9.364-7), and thus *promissa* functions too as a reference to Odysseus joining the Trojan War as one of Helen's suitors. **uxorem maestam puerumque** refers to Penelope and Telemachus where *maestam* is predicative.

107-119 Achilles' deliberation on the shore (Hom. *Il.* 9.410-29). **audet** makes clear his decision. **contra... uasto:** Achilles wrestling Scamander (Hom. *Il.* 21.1-33; *Il. Lat.* 20.917-8). **quattuor** refers to Achilles killing Iphition, Demoleon, Hippodamas and Polydorus at the beginning of his *aristeia* (Hom. *Il.* 20.353-418), Ignotus is not so successful.

109 umeris: Ignotus is doing the real heavy lifting, and fulfilling what C. should have (cf. lines 51 and 54).

110 The four starting dactyls portray Ignotus' movements with the speed which C. attributes to himself in his political commentaries but has not yet shown.

112-24 fidens... Caesareum: recalls C.'s earlier assurance *vobiscum stabo*, and makes *ob promissa* all the more tragic as his loyalty proves unrequited. **geminos... fratres:** 'twin brothers' who are killed by *uno conamine* literally thrust through them in the word order. **geminum... fraterna:** in a tragic turn of events, both of Ignotus' heels are sliced and the first thing he looks for as he falls to the ground are his brothers on the battlefield; the Romans do not share the same comradeship as the Britons (cf. line 88).

119-21 et ueluti... grauantur: the simile makes Ignotus become Virgil's Euryalus (*A.* 9.435-7) and by extension Homer's Gorgythion (*Il.* 8.306-8).

122-6 dumque...dolos: as though time has stopped, the narrator returns to discuss Ignotus' thoughts while falling. He becomes Hector realising that (Athena disguised as) Deiphobus had vanished (Hom. *Il.* 22.295-300; *Il. Lat.* 22.969). **dolos:** the *aristeia* of Ignotus races through the entire Roman epic cycle – from the beginnings of the Trojan War to the War in Latium – but his seemingly Odyssean introduction crumbles as he falls victim to *dolos*, as does the Hectorean conclusion when his corpse is not returned to his family nor protected by the gods against the elements.

125-6: the marine reimagination of the Homeric convention of corpses being eaten by animals (e.g. Hom. *Il.* 1.1-6, 3.279, 14.161-65, 22.422). **nova tecta** the grim image carries the implication of the ecological destruction this battle has already caused.

127-9 The historical digression connects the ancient to the modern with *ad hoc tempus* and provides an aetiology for the Tomb of the Unknown Warrior in Westminster Abbey and remembrance poppy. **sine nomine...** **Ignotus** explains that 'Ignotus' is an artificial name, and refers back to the structure of the poem where C. is *sine nomine*. Ignotus, as a parallel model of C., highlights his cowardice and absence from the battlefield. **papaueri campi** converts Virgilian simile into the remembrance poppy, and *nos* conveys that, although Roman, the British view the casualties of war as universal and not, as C. sees it, a means to an end.

130-8 Divine Spectators

The Romans' *magnis dis* (cf. line 4) come into view as the narrator answers line 124: *quae numina poscat?*

133-5 Mars... inundant: the gods are arranged in speaking tableau: Mars laughing, Neptune choking, Nereids and Venus weeping. In contrast to the Celtic gods (cf. lines 45 and 104). **Genetrice** refers directly to *Venus Genetrix*, but the image of a mother weeping alongside the Nereids recalls Thetis (Hom. *Il.* 18.38-51). The Nereids are with Venus (but here referred to as *Genetrix* to be) crying on the beach as Thetis in *Iliad* 18.

136-7 Parcae... tinctis: the image of the Fates weaving and their actions mimicking the trajectory of missiles on from the battlefield is adapted from the skaldic poem *Darraðarljóð* in chapter 157 of *Njáls saga* which has the Valkyries weave and choose who are to be slain at the Battle of Clontarf in April 1014 – the Vikings are future invaders of the British Isles. **stamina:** works as both threads and life-forces

139-50 Caesar wanders the battlefield; the aetiology of the British flag

The Romans are ultimately victorious and only then does C. disembark and wade through the battlefield. The narrator concludes with a note on balanced historiography.

139-42 tempus... descendit: time stands still and, unlike typical epic convention where night signals the end of a battle, the phrase 'the sun never sets on the British empire', oft applied to the British Empire in the 19th century, is here used literally. **donec Victoria tandem:** winks momentarily at the Golden Age of the British Empire under Queen Victoria (r.1837-1901) but *Victoria* here refers to the Roman goddess. **rapide:** comes at the end of the asyndetic tricolon, showcasing C.'s unprecedented rapidity; unlike Ignotus, his movements are skittish. **descendit:** recalls line 71, C. is exactly twice as slow as the rest of his army.

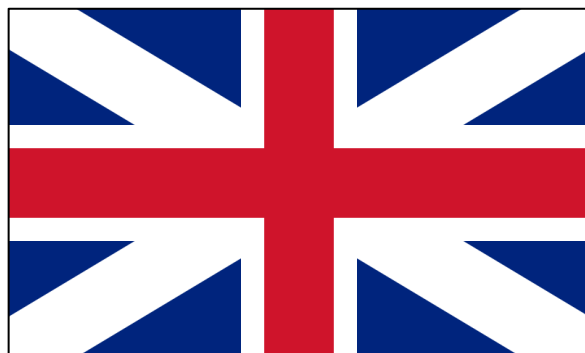
141 lupae... leones: the pastoral metaphor of a she-wolf fighting lions refers to the two sides' national animals, a method of propaganda employed against Richard III by William Collingbourne in his story *The Cat, the Rat and the Dog*, and by Henry VII's red dragon standard at the Battle of Bosworth Field in August 1485 (his invasion of the British Isles).

143 membra uirumque: a bilingual joke on Vergil's *incipit*: 'the arms and the man'.

145 A versification of the final assertion of Calgacus' speech to his troops in advance of the Battle of Mons Graupius in Tacitus' *Agricola* 30: *ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant*.

146-9 candida... tergatur: the flag's aetiology emerges through colour terminology. The chalk of Britain and C.'s two attempts to invade and draw blood illustrates Saint George's Cross, and the blue waters from Scotland flow in from all sides to complete the flag of Great Britain:

149-50 sic... historiae: the poem ends with a metapoetic declaration reminiscent of Lucan's *Pharsalia* 9.985-6, and the tibicen metrically enacts the *dimidium* it describes.



What have the Romans ever done for us?

On the British war

That man marvels at himself, captivated by his appearance's reflection,
he who once tried to touch the waters with his hand –
the Atlantic waters that is – and now leads the Romans into battle
with the senators, people, Penates and mighty gods.
Behold how richly crowned his temples are in mist, 5
and how that man, standing on the high stern, exudes over the waves!
Not unlike the son of Helios who twisted his father's reins
in the heavenly chariot and reached the world's edge,
then, caked in pitchy darkness, where he was going or where he was
he had no idea – so like him that man is enveloped in smoke from all sides 10
as he charges headlong into unknown shadows, where the known world ends
and the sky is mixed with mournful murmuring.
But he kept a steady course and favourable winds,
and did not perish suddenly – but Fortuna demands her bribes:
for his beloved daughter breathed her final breath not long after, 15
a sacrificial victim whom the gods had duly approved for his journey.
Who is so cruel to have willingly accepted that price?
Who was so out of his damn mind he came to the shores of Britain,
saw, and believed that he had conquered this land for eternity?

It was Julius Caesar, he alone achieved such feats, 20
and the 700 ships and strength of 6 legions
and the charge of 2000 cavalry helped.
Even while the fleet is spread far and wide, the ocean is hidden beneath it.
Tired they now all steer slowly to the left,
and, straining, they churn the foam and sweep the blue sea, 25
enthusiastic in their minds: some to obtain Fame's snowy pearls
to bring back for their mothers and the future wives of their household;
others already to show themselves in triumphal procession
clothed in tin; and others to hold onto rights more than civil
and soon become more of a king than a member of society. 30

Now from the icy mist, a row of three chalky cliffs
 suddenly rose up, and at the same time rain looms over these ships,
 just like Scylla dripping with her six three-toothed mouths.
 The hollow ships' timbers groan, like the sorrowful bodies
 of those suffering in torture, which used to stand in the heart of Gallic groves, 35
 but were now enslaved by the Latin destruction of axes,
 they warned their oak friends on the shore.
 Look, a large country rises up with a monstrous border!
 And Caesar looking up at the menacing nation on a hill
 sees them packed together to lie low and chariots arriving, 40
 fear stricken he chatters his teeth and tottering takes a step back.
 Now suddenly a Roman ship smashed against the British rocks,
 shatters into pieces, and ship upon ship followed
 amidst dreadful shouting; the aether resounds with their cries,
 and now the son of Lir with only his right hand drags those unlucky ones 45
 to his kingdom in the deep; and now they decorate with their bones
 the altars of the lord of the sea, beneath his huge abyss.
 The horses were mindful first and with their neighing they foreshadowed their future fates,
 and trembled in fear, for massacre was about to occur,
 and sweat was dripping now mixed in with the rain. 50

Lifting on his shoulders the fame and fates of his ancestors,
 his royal voice spoke among these loud sounds: "Citizens,
 Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears.
 Ah, how great a weight Fortune has taken off my shoulders!
 On the Ides, Luna glistened blood-red in the sky: 55
 Mars gave us this sign to show his approval of our assassination!
 O how fortunate Rome is to have me as its leader!
 I will be by your side: we will fight them on the beaches,
 we will fight them in the streets, we will fight them in the fields,
 and we will conquer them on the hill; we shall never surrender to the enemy! 60
 Rule, Romulean realm! rule without end,
 Romans never will bear the shackles of a slave on their feet.
 Carry on, Trojans, and keep calm! Now will be our finest hour."
 He spoke and from his scabbard he drew forth his lightning sword,
 and struck the mooring ropes with his blade. 65

The same fiery spirit seizes them all at once; they snatch their weapons and charge;
as when chariots burst forth from the gates of the circus
and race into the arena, and the driver, pulling in vain at the reins,
is carried off by the horses, his chariot ignoring his commands.

But afterwards, stuck in the mud, the fleet ran short against the shallows. 70

There, the fleet had descended into the grisly arena
(here in summer you will see castles, and a number of the town coming together
in the game of bulls and dogs rather near the sea

where it will be the custom to compete for the Aegean palm,
with skin burned, while tubers and fishes are devoured). 75

Now nothing. The Asturian horse (who has hooves
shaped like human fingers and a mane luxurious with hair untied)
barely departs a nail's breadth – if Caesar had himself
attempted to mount him, how different the fates would have been!

But the army itself is stuck in the middle of the marsh. 80

Look now, a pale woman hides herself in the middle of the arms,
hisses slithering through her ranks like a serpent,
and inspires their hearts with her dreadful words.

Meanwhile, as is customary, the queen assembled her followers
in three long columns (a people who love to queue) 85

into the British battle line, whose backs the archers protect,
and the cavalry and fierce foot soldiers hold fast in the middle.

We few (we happy band of brothers) hurl weapons from high,
and we do not hold back in hurting the mob.

The heaps of the slain gradually rises, and over the fallen 90
the standard-bearers tread like Nymphs on lilies,

until they touch dry ground, where at last they plant their standard;
the golden Roman bird, with unwilling wings, into the sky
is forced to fly upwards through the inauspicious fields.

Who would have believed that the empire of this small shore 95
would one day encompass the world and rise greater than Rome's?

And now the crowded army, with the scarlet cloth of their cloaks,
fills the entire virgin bank, like a woman in a ruptured childbirth,

who, violated by her husband, discharges bloody blood
and, after their marriage bed is stained, her stinking organs 100
and entrails and foetus too, and raves like a bacchant; the virgin earth reddens
and is now for the first time dishonoured by a foreign enemy.
The Romans' shout rises up to the heavens and in response
the druids then send down their discordant songs to lord Donn.

Ignotus himself, who because of an oath had reluctantly left behind 105
his wife mourning and his son in order to take up arms,
while turning over in his mind whether glory or a homecoming would be better,
he fights against the waters and breaks through the opposing floods
and now breaking them in half by arms, now by vast chest,
he leaps forth before the others, a soldier inspiring in sword and shield, 110
and dares to throw himself into the midst of the enemy.
Alone, he takes on four men (trusting his commander,
Caesar, to be by his side); with a spear ripped from a corpse,
he pierces two leaders with a single thrust.

The third falls by his sword – in piercing his throat through his ribs 115
he then accidentally floods his vision with a splatter of blood from the wound.
But he carried on blind, raging in mind and weapon,
when he was undercut in both ankles (a cruel fate!) and falls on the field,
just as a flower cut by the plow droops and wilts as it dies,
or poppies with tired necks bow their heads, 120
weighed down by chance rainfall.

And as he falls backward and in his dire straits
looks for his brothers' help, he sees that there is no salvation,
and he senses the trickery that has occurred. What can he do? Which gods should he call upon?
He will be neither remembered nor saved; his wounds they fill 125
crabs and vile fish, seeking new homes.

And for this reason, we still give those bodies without a name
to be buried in the tomb of the Unknown Soldier,
which is now frequented and wreathed by the poppy of the battlefield.

The battle raged from every point of view, here blood mixes with gore, 130
there entrails mix with brains; nerves drift in the whirlpool,
as do trembling fingers and every sort of limb.

Mars, smiling above, delights as Neptune's throat
is choked with blood, and as all the Nereids,
with the Mother, flood the shores again with their tears. 135

Meanwhile, the Fates, who had only just weaved through their warp
long movements that imitated the spears in their flight,
now hasten with their fingers dripping and stained with blood.

Time is sluggishly absent; the sun never entirely sets
on the British empire until at last Victoria 140
and Fors Fortuna favour the she-wolf, the lions retreat,
only now does Caesar hurriedly disembark onto the shore, and floats among
the arms and the man, like when arms were once
reaching out to him in Rome and seeking his favour.

Where he makes a desert, he calls it peace, 145
and for that reason those he conquered preserve the battle in their flag,
an innocent race: the redness is dyed in a cross on the white plain,
while the gore is wiped from the chalk by Scottish waves from every side.

Thus by no generation will be lost
our half of history. 150